1.1 Setting Up the Government

Would you want to be president of the United States? You might be surprised to hear that George Washington did *not* want the job. He knew that being the first president of the new country wouldn't be easy. But his countrymen wanted Washington.

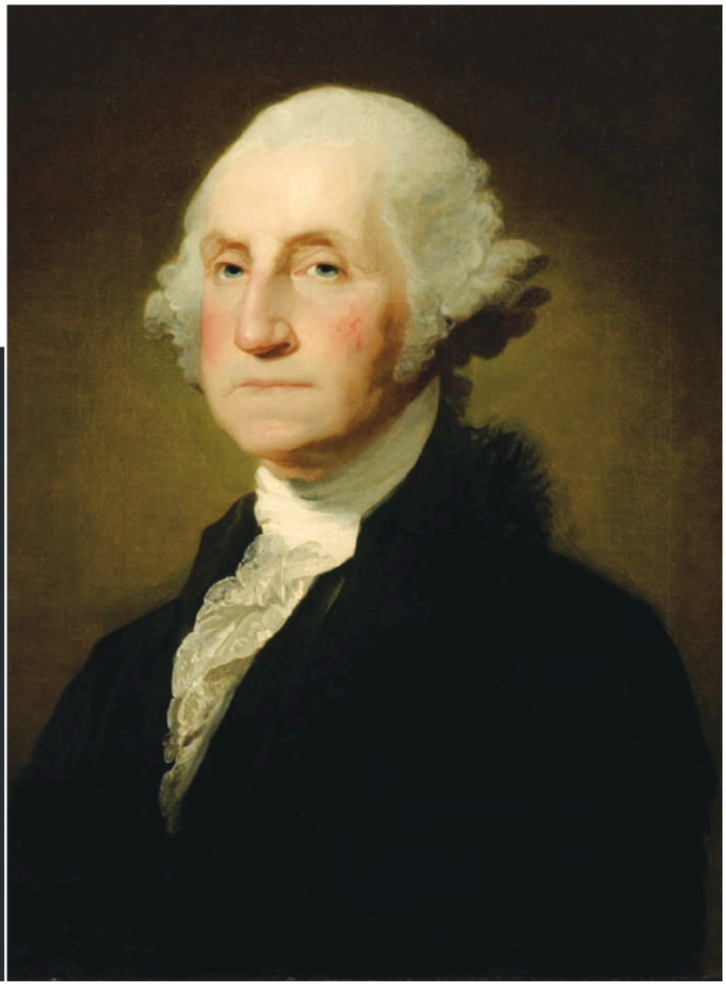
MAIN IDEA The Constitution established some guidelines, but for the first president, starting up the new government was a complex and difficult undertaking.

THE FIRST PRESIDENT

George Washington was the obvious choice to be the nation's first president—he was a dignified man of strong character. Better yet, he was a natural leader, which he had proved during the American Revolution. Success in the new republic was not at all assured, but Washington accepted the challenge. Even though he didn't want the job, Washington guided the new government through its early years.

As the newly written Constitution directed, the electoral college determined who would be president in this first election—not the people. Every one of the 69 electors voted for Washington. The reluctant candidate won hands down. John Adams, who was runner-up, became the vice president.

On April 23, 1789, thousands of cheering citizens in New York City, the country's temporary capital, welcomed Washington. He took the oath of office a week later and began his difficult task. Washington had to invent the role of president as he went along. "My station is new; and . . . [I] walk on untrodden ground," he wrote in a letter. Everything he did would set a **precedent**, or establish an example, for all future presidents.



The Clark Art Institute Williamstown, Massachusetts

Gilbert Stuart painted 104 portraits of George Washington, including the one shown here, which was painted some time between 1796 and 1803. John Jay, whom you may remember as an author of *The Federalist* papers, introduced Washington to the painter. Stuart began creating his likenesses of the president in 1795. Washington became extremely impatient sitting for his portrait, however. Even though Stuart was known as an entertaining conversationalist, Washington remained mostly silent during their sessions.

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

Washington particularly wanted to make it clear that he was *president* of the United States, not its *king*. He dressed plainly for his **inauguration**, the ceremony that marked the beginning of his presidency, in an American-made brown suit. And he refused to be called "His Excellency" or "Your Highness," as John Adams had suggested. After much debate, Washington decided that "Mr. President" would do just fine.

AN OCEAN OF DIFFICULTIES

Once in office, Washington got to work—and there was a lot to do. As he himself described it, the nation faced "an ocean of difficulties." The new government had to deal with problems within the country as well as conflicts in the Northwest Territory and wars across the Atlantic.

To tackle all these situations, both the president and Congress had certain responsibilities and powers, as spelled out in the Constitution. Essentially, Congress would make the laws, and the president would ensure they were carried out.

But not everything was covered in the Constitution. Here, too, Washington set precedents. For example, he took control of treaty negotiations, bypassing Congress, and established a policy of neutrality in foreign conflicts—insisting it was within the president's power to do so.

Fortunately, the framers of the Constitution did foresee the need for departments to assist the president. Congress had the power to create the departments, and the president decided who would head them. Together, the heads of the departments are called a **Cabinet**.

Washington picked men from a variety of geographical areas and with a mix of political views for his Cabinet. He strongly advocated political moderation and tried to keep himself, as president, above the bickering that went on between political factions. That way, he believed, he could do what was best for the country. Washington appointed a group of highly talented men to his Cabinet—and hoped they'd put aside their political differences, too.

The First Inaugural Address

Washington wasn't required to give a speech at his inauguration, but he decided to do so. Every president since has done the same. To mark the occasion, people attending the ceremony could purchase copper buttons, like the ones below, as souvenirs.

As he gave this First Inaugural Address, Washington was nervous. His hands and voice trembled, but his words were powerful: "The preservation of the sacred fire of liberty, and the destiny of the Republican model of government, are justly considered as deeply . . . staked on the experiment entrusted to the hands of the American people." In other words, the future of the country depended on the success of this new government.



Washington inaugural souvenirs

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did George Washington write that he was walking "on untrodden ground"?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** How did Washington deal with treaty negotiations, since no process was spelled out in the Constitution?
3. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** How did Washington's presidency help establish an American identity?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.